INTERVIEW

"We are telling the Naxals, it's either *goli* or *boli*"

Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai spoke to Raj Chengappa and Rahul Noronha on how his state has been tackling Naxalism. Excerpts:



Q. What is the government doing to end Naxalism in your state by the March 31, 2026, deadline?

We have studied the surrender and rehabilitation policy of other states and are trying to offer the best possible terms. We have allocated 15,000 units under the PM Awas Yojana to surrendered Naxals and are giving them jobs and skilling them. We have had unprecedented results in eliminating Maoists and ensuring surrenders. Our message to the Naxals is clear: if you understand the language of *goli* (violence), then we will respond accordingly, but if you understand the language of *boli* (talks), then you are welcome to surrender and join the mainstream. We are on track to attaining the target of eliminating Maoism by March 31, 2026.

Q. What are you doing to win the hearts of people living in Naxal areas?

We have a scheme called Niyad Nellanar which means Your Ideal Village. Under this, security forces at camps work in villages in a 5 km radius to provide local residents the benefits of more than 30 schemes and citizen services like Aadhaar and Ayushman cards. To engage with youth, we organised the Bastar Olympics, which saw the participation of 1.65 lakh youth from the ages of 18-35, of which half were women. The Union home minister was here for the closing ceremony. He has also promised that there will be no shortage of funds from the Centre to tackle the Naxal threat.

Q. How is your approach to dealing with Naxalism different from the preceding Congress government's?

When the Congress was in power in the state, the Naxals openly claimed that it was 'their' government. It was the same set of officers who were battling it, but didn't show results as the Congress government did not have the will to tackle Naxalism. ■



WINNING HEARTS

INCLUSIVE REFORMS

The Niyad Nellanar scheme launched in February 2024 is proving to be a game-changer by extending basic amenities and welfare projects to 125 villages most affected by Naxalism in Chhattisgarh

14,458 Ayushman cards issued

24,177 Aadhaar cards issued

23 Schools sanctioned

130 Anganwadis sanctioned

41 Ration shops sanctioned

in Maharashtra. "Abujhmaad was impregnable and there was no security presence earlier, but now we have nine camps inside it. This has considerably reduced the security vacuum area in Abujhmaad," says Sundarraj. The other area of concern is the National Park or forested area within the Indravati Tiger Reserve in Bijapur district. Of late, this area has seen intensified operations, including a recent